EST. SEPTEMBER 8, 2026

NAIJA FC COLUMBUS

Constitution, *Rules &* Regulations

A Constitution for Unity, Discipline, Safety, Fairness & Brotherhood

"One Team. Many Backgrounds. One Naija."

LOCATION	VERSION	ADOPTED	EFFECTIVE DATE
Columbus, Ohio, USA	1.0		

NAIJA FC COLUMBUS

Contents

—	Preamble & Foundational Principles	3
I	Mission, Vision & Core Values	3
II	Membership & Eligibility	4
III	Unity & Anti-Tribalism Policy	6
IV	Leadership & Governance	7
V	Elections, Terms & Accountability	8
VI	Match-Day Operations	10
VII	Player Safety & On-Field Conduct	11
VIII	Verbal Abuse, Harassment & Violence	12
IX	Referees, Opponents & Sportsmanship	13
X	Attendance, Commitment & Player Selection	13
XI	Finance & Financial Transparency	14
XII	Social Media, Substance Use & Match Integrity	15
XIII	Complaints, Investigation & Discipline	15
XIV	Disciplinary Points System	16
XV	Appeals & Fair Process	18
XVI	Meetings, Voting & Amendments	18
XVII	Player Registration & Commitment Agreement	19
XVIII	Signature & Acknowledgment	21

> In this Constitution, **"must"** and **"will"** mean something is required. **"Should"** means it is expected or recommended. **"May"** means it is allowed but not required.

OPENING

Preamble

We, the members of Naija FC Columbus, adopt this Constitution and Rules & Regulations to build a football club founded on unity, discipline, respect, safety, fairness, accountability and brotherhood.

Naija FC Columbus is a community football club for Nigerian men in Columbus, Ohio. Nigeria is made up of many ethnic groups, languages, cultures, religions, regions and traditions. That diversity is a strength and must never be used to divide the club.

We will compete with passion, and we will not let football rivalry, personal disagreements, ethnic identity, friendship groups, money or leadership ambitions destroy our unity.

A respected club is built on the character of its members, not only their talent. Every member is responsible for protecting the safety, dignity, reputation and future of Naija FC Columbus.

"Football may bring us together, but character will keep us together."

Foundational Principle

The club belongs to all of its members together. No individual, family, friendship group, ethnic group or leadership faction owns Naija FC Columbus or has a permanent right to control it.

Supremacy of This Constitution

All members, players, coaches, captains, officers and committee members are bound by this Constitution.

If a league, facility, referee authority, insurance requirement or law sets a stricter requirement on a specific matter, that stricter requirement applies to that matter.

ARTICLE

I

Mission, Vision & Core Values

SECTION 1 **Mission**

To provide a competitive, organized, safe, inclusive and respectful football environment for Nigerian men in Columbus, Ohio, while building lasting friendship, community and pride.

SECTION 2 Vision

To be a respected Nigerian community football club known for excellent sportsmanship, disciplined players, transparent leadership, strong organization, player safety, and unity across ethnic and cultural backgrounds.

SECTION 3 Core Values

Unity	We stay one club, whatever our ethnic, cultural, religious, regional or personal background.
Respect	We treat teammates, opponents, officials, coaches, spectators and community members with dignity.
Discipline	We follow the rules, arrive prepared, control our behavior and accept accountability.
Safety	Football is never an excuse for dangerous or violent conduct.
Fairness	Club opportunities and decisions are based on legitimate criteria, not favoritism or tribal identity.
Brotherhood	We support one another on and off the field while respecting healthy boundaries.
Integrity	We are honest about money, membership, leadership, match conduct and club affairs.
Excellence	We keep improving our football, our organization and our character.

SECTION 4 Club Motto

“One Team. Many Backgrounds. One Naija.”

ARTICLE

II

Membership & Eligibility

SECTION 1 Age Requirement

Membership is open only to people aged 18 or older. No one under 18 may register as a player.

SECTION 2 Nigerian Membership

The club’s primary membership is Nigerian men living in or around Columbus, Ohio. The club may set reasonable location or roster requirements when needed for league participation.

SECTION 3 Registration

Before taking part in official club activities, every player must complete the official registration process and acknowledge this Constitution. Players must:

1. Give accurate registration information.
2. Give an emergency contact when asked.
3. Pay approved registration, league, uniform or other required fees by the stated deadline.
4. Agree to follow the Constitution and disciplinary procedures.

SECTION 4 Good Standing

A member is in good standing when he:

- Is properly registered.
- Has met required financial obligations.
- Is not suspended.
- Is following club rules.
- Is making a reasonable effort to take part in club activities.

SECTION 5 Non-Nigerian Friends at Practice

A registered member may invite a non-Nigerian friend aged 18 or older to a practice, training session or informal practice game. Guest participation depends on:

1. Approval by the coach, manager or designated organizer.
2. Available space.
3. Player safety.
4. Facility requirements.
5. Insurance requirements.
6. Applicable league or competition rules.

The inviting member must introduce the guest to the organizer and make sure the guest understands the club's basic rules.

A guest:

- Does not automatically become a club member.
- Must follow the same safety and conduct rules while taking part.
- May not play in an official league or tournament match unless the competition rules allow it and the club approves.

The club may limit or refuse guest participation when needed for safety, space, insurance, facility or competition reasons.

SECTION 6 Suspension or Termination of Membership

Membership may be suspended or terminated for serious or repeated violations of this Constitution.

A person may be removed from an activity immediately and temporarily when needed to protect the safety of players, officials or others.

ARTICLE

III

Unity & Anti-Tribalism Policy

SECTION 1 Equal Membership

No member may be given preferential treatment, excluded, intimidated, harassed or disadvantaged because of his:

- Ethnic group
- State of origin
- Language
- Region
- Religion
- Political affiliation
- Financial status
- Social background

SECTION 2 Tribal Pride vs. Tribalism

Members may be proud of their ethnic, regional or cultural heritage. Tribalism becomes a club issue when ethnic identity is used to:

- Discriminate.
- Exclude.
- Intimidate.
- Divide.
- Control leadership.
- Gain unfair advantage.
- Attack another member.

SECTION 3 Prohibited Conduct

The following are prohibited:

1. Tribal or ethnic slurs.
2. Ethnic insults.
3. Organized exclusion of members based on ethnicity.
4. Recruiting or campaigning for control of the club mainly through ethnic division.
5. Threatening or humiliating members because of their background.
6. Creating unofficial tribal factions to control club decisions.
7. Telling members that another ethnic group should not hold leadership positions.
8. Using club resources to promote ethnic division.

SECTION 4 Leadership Representation

No leadership office is reserved for any ethnic group. Leaders are chosen based on:

- Character
- Integrity
- Reliability
- Commitment
- Leadership ability
- Competence
- Ability to serve the entire club

The club should also seek inclusive leadership and avoid structures that consistently make members feel the club belongs to one ethnic group.

SECTION 5 Tribal and Political Neutrality

The club will not endorse tribal political campaigns or use club resources to promote ethnic factions.

Members are free to keep their personal cultural identities and relationships, but must not use them to divide or control the club.

SECTION 6 Enforcement

Allegations of ethnic discrimination will be taken seriously and reviewed through the club's complaint and disciplinary process. No one may be retaliated against for making a good-faith complaint.

ARTICLE

IV

Leadership & Governance

SECTION 1 Executive Structure

The club may have the following leadership positions:

1. President
2. Vice President
3. Secretary
4. Treasurer
5. General Coordinator
6. Head Coach / Team Manager
7. Disciplinary & Welfare Officer

The club may create additional positions when needed.

SECTION 2 Duties of Leadership

POSITION	RESPONSIBILITIES
President	Provides overall leadership; represents the club; makes sure the Constitution is followed; promotes unity and fairness; coordinates major organizational decisions.
Vice President	Assists the President; carries out delegated responsibilities; takes on appropriate responsibilities when the President is unavailable.
Secretary	Keeps club records and membership documents; records important meeting decisions; handles official notices and communications.
Treasurer	Keeps financial records; tracks income and expenses; keeps receipts; prepares financial reports; helps prepare club budgets.
General Coordinator	Coordinates match schedules, training schedules, facilities, equipment, uniforms and match-day logistics.
Head Coach / Team Manager	Oversees training, football preparation, tactical organization, player readiness and match-day football operations.
Disciplinary & Welfare Officer	Assists with player welfare, safety concerns, complaints, disciplinary matters and conflict resolution.

SECTION 3 Duty to the Whole Club

Leaders must act for the benefit of Naija FC Columbus as a whole. They must not use their positions to unfairly reward friends, family members, business partners, tribal groups, financial supporters or personal allies.

SECTION 4 Conflict of Interest

A leader must disclose any personal, family, business or financial relationship that could reasonably affect a club decision. The leader may be required to stay out of that decision.

ARTICLE

V

Elections, Terms & Accountability

SECTION 1 Elections

Leadership positions are filled through a fair election process approved by the membership. The club may use secret ballots, open voting, electronic voting, or another documented voting method approved by the membership.

SECTION 2 Leadership Term

Elected leadership positions have two-year terms, unless the membership approves otherwise.

SECTION 3 Eligibility for Office

A candidate for leadership must:

1. Be at least 18 years old.
2. Be a member in good standing.
3. Show reliable participation.
4. Show good character.
5. Not be serving a disciplinary suspension at the time of the election.

SECTION 4 Campaigning

Members may support candidates and discuss club priorities. Campaigning must not involve:

- Threats
- Bribery
- Intimidation
- Tribal discrimination
- Misuse of club funds
- False accusations
- Promises of special benefits to a tribal or personal faction

SECTION 5 Removal of Leaders

A leader may be removed for:

- Serious misconduct
- Financial misconduct
- Abuse of authority
- Discrimination
- Violence
- Repeated neglect of duties
- Serious ethical violations
- Conduct that significantly harms the club

The leader must be given a fair chance to respond before final removal, unless immediate temporary action is needed for safety or to protect the integrity of the club.

SECTION 6 Vacancies

If an office becomes vacant, the Executive Committee may appoint an interim officer until the next reasonable election or membership vote.

ARTICLE

VI

Match-Day Operations

SECTION 1 Match Check-In

Players must check in with the designated match-day coordinator when they arrive. Arrival order is based on when a player is physically present and checked in, not when he sends a message saying he is on the way.

SECTION 2 First 22 Rule

KEY RULE

For organized full-sided practice games or internal scrimmages, **the first 22 eligible players to physically arrive and check in form the initial 22-player match group.** In an 11-versus-11 format, those 22 players form two teams of 11, using the method chosen by the coach or match organizer.

This rule is designed to encourage punctuality, reduce arguments, reward commitment, and create a clear and transparent system.

The First 22 Rule does not override safety requirements, suspensions, league rules, facility rules, eligibility requirements or referee decisions.

SECTION 3 More Than 22 Players

When more than 22 eligible players arrive, those beyond the first 22 join the rotation/substitution group. The coach or match organizer will set a reasonable rotation system.

SECTION 4 Official League Matches

For official league or tournament matches, the club follows the competition's roster, eligibility, substitution and match-day rules. Where league rules differ from this internal practice-game policy, league rules take precedence.

SECTION 5 Late Arrival

A player who arrives after the first 22 places are filled should not demand immediate inclusion or replace a player who arrived earlier. The organizer may make an exception when a change is needed because of injury, safety, team balance, competition requirements, or other legitimate organizational reasons.

ARTICLE

VII

Player Safety & On-Field Conduct

SECTION 1 No Sliding Tackles

Sliding tackles are prohibited in club practices, internal games and organized scrimmages, unless the club formally adopts a different rule for a specific competition. A player may be disciplined for an intentional sliding challenge even if no one is injured.

SECTION 2 Dangerous Play

The following are prohibited:

1. Two-footed challenges.
2. High-foot challenges likely to endanger another player.
3. Late challenges intended to intimidate or injure.
4. Reckless tackles from behind.
5. Deliberate contact after the ball is no longer reasonably playable.
6. Any action reasonably intended to injure another person.

SECTION 3 Safety Authority

A referee, coach, manager or designated safety officer may remove a player from an activity when that player presents an immediate safety risk.

SECTION 4 Injuries

Players must report significant injuries. Teammates must not pressure an injured player to continue when doing so may create more risk.

SECTION 5 Equipment

Players must:

- Wear appropriate footwear.
- Follow facility requirements.
- Follow league equipment rules.
- Remove jewelry or other unsafe items when required.

ARTICLE

VIII

Verbal Abuse, Harassment & Violence

SECTION 1 Verbal Abuse

Frustration is a normal part of competitive football. However, the following are prohibited:

- Repeated personal abuse.
- Threats.
- Tribal slurs.
- Ethnic insults.
- Religious insults.
- Sexual harassment.
- Humiliating comments.
- Threatening language.
- Repeated abusive language directed at teammates or opponents.

SECTION 2 Physical Altercations

KEY RULE

Naija FC Columbus has a **zero-tolerance** approach to fighting. The following are prohibited:

- Punching.
- Kicking another person outside legitimate football play.
- Choking.
- Aggressive pushing.
- Grabbing someone aggressively.
- Striking another person.
- Chasing someone with the intention of fighting.
- Encouraging others to fight.

SECTION 3 Players Not Involved in an Altercation

Players who are not directly involved must not join the confrontation. They should follow the direction of the referee, captain, coach, manager or club official, and help calm the situation when it is safe to do so.

SECTION 4 Threats

Threats of physical harm are serious violations wherever they happen: on the field, during practice, in the locker area, at club meetings, by text message or on social media.

SECTION 5 Harassment

Repeated unwanted conduct that humiliates, intimidates or targets another member, or interferes with his participation, may count as harassment and may lead to disciplinary action.

ARTICLE

IX

Referees, Opponents & Sportsmanship

SECTION 1 Respect for Officials

Players may disagree with a referee's decision, but must do so respectfully. Players may not threaten, aggressively touch, surround, chase, insult or intimidate referees.

SECTION 2 Captain as Primary Communicator

Where practical, the team captain is the main player who speaks with the referee about match decisions. Other players should let the captain handle routine clarification.

SECTION 3 Opponents

Opponents are competitors, not enemies. Trash talk that crosses into threats, personal abuse, discriminatory language or deliberate provocation is prohibited.

SECTION 4 Post-Match Conduct

Players are encouraged to acknowledge opponents and officials after matches. A player who is still angry after a match must walk away from the conflict rather than continue the argument.

SECTION 5 Club Reputation

Members represent Naija FC Columbus whenever they take part in organized club activities. Conduct that repeatedly damages the club's reputation may lead to disciplinary action.

ARTICLE

X

Attendance, Commitment & Player Selection

SECTION 1 Attendance

Players are expected to attend scheduled practices and matches, and should let the club know in advance when they cannot attend.

SECTION 2 Punctuality

Players should normally arrive 30–45 minutes before kickoff, or at the time set by the match organizer.

SECTION 3 Repeated Absence

Repeated unexcused absences may affect match eligibility, player selection, playing opportunities and membership status. The club should distinguish genuine emergencies from avoidable repeated absences.

SECTION 4 Player Selection

For official matches, selection may consider attendance, fitness, training performance, tactical needs, position requirements, teamwork, discipline, match readiness and commitment.

SECTION 5 No Tribal or Personal Selection

No player may be selected, excluded, benched or given special treatment because of tribe, friendship, family relationship, financial contribution or personal loyalty to a leader.

SECTION 6 Playing Time

Membership does not guarantee unlimited playing time. Coaches and managers may make reasonable football decisions while treating all players with respect and applying the club's fairness principles.

ARTICLE

XI

Finance & Financial Transparency

SECTION 1 Club Funds

All money collected in the name of Naija FC Columbus belongs to the club and must be used for legitimate club purposes.

SECTION 2 Financial Records

The club will keep appropriate records of income, expenses, receipts, club purchases, registration fees, match fees, tournament fees, uniform expenses and facility expenses. Club funds should be kept separate from personal funds whenever practical.

SECTION 3 Treasurer

The Treasurer keeps accurate records and gives the membership periodic financial reports.

SECTION 4 Unauthorized Personal Use

No officer or member may use club money for personal purposes without authorization. Misuse or theft of club funds is grounds for serious disciplinary action and may be reported to the appropriate authorities when necessary.

SECTION 5 Fees

The club will clearly communicate registration, match, uniform, tournament and other required fees before collecting them.

SECTION 6 Financial Transparency

Members in good standing may receive reasonable summaries of club finances. Individual members' personal financial information should not be shared unnecessarily.

ARTICLE

XII

Social Media, Substance Use & Match Integrity

SECTION 1 Social Media

Members may share personal opinions but must not falsely claim to speak for Naija FC Columbus. Official club announcements should be made only by authorized representatives. Members must not use social media to:

- Threaten teammates.
- Threaten opponents.
- Publicly harass teammates.
- Publish confidential disciplinary matters without authorization.
- Promote tribal attacks.
- Misrepresent club decisions.
- Intentionally damage the club's reputation.

SECTION 2 Alcohol & Impairment

No player may train or play while impaired by alcohol or drugs. A coach or organizer may remove an apparently impaired player for safety reasons.

SECTION 3 Gambling & Match Integrity

Players must not:

- Manipulate match results.
- Deliberately underperform for improper reasons.
- Offer or accept improper benefits to influence a match.
- Engage in match fixing.
- Take part in conduct that compromises the integrity of the team or competition.

SECTION 4 Club Property

Club uniforms, equipment, balls, cones, trophies, flags and other assets remain club property unless stated otherwise. Members must take reasonable care of club property.

ARTICLE

XIII

Complaints, Investigation & Discipline

SECTION 1 Reporting

A member may report suspected misconduct to the President, the Secretary, the Disciplinary & Welfare Officer, or another designated leader when the usual person is involved in the complaint.

SECTION 2 Good-Faith Complaints

No one may be retaliated against simply for reporting a concern in good faith.

SECTION 3 Preliminary Review

The club may do an initial review to decide whether the matter is minor, can be resolved informally, or requires a formal disciplinary process.

SECTION 4 Right to Be Heard

For serious allegations, the member should receive:

- Notice of the concern.
- A reasonable chance to explain his side.
- A chance to provide relevant information.
- A chance to name relevant witnesses.

SECTION 5 Confidentiality

The club should protect the privacy of those involved as far as reasonably possible. Confidentiality cannot be guaranteed where disclosure is needed for safety, legal compliance, league requirements, facility requirements or a fair investigation.

SECTION 6 Interim Measures

While a serious matter is being reviewed, a player may be temporarily removed from training or matches when needed to protect safety, preserve the integrity of an investigation, or comply with league requirements.

ARTICLE

XIV

Disciplinary Points System

This points system promotes consistency and accountability. Leadership may set the points within each range based on severity, intent, prior disciplinary history, injury caused, threats, cooperation and other relevant circumstances.

VIOLATION	SUGGESTED POINTS
Minor disrespect / arguing after warning	1
Repeated lateness or avoidable unexcused absence	1
Unsportsmanlike conduct	1–2
Abusive language toward teammate/opponent	2–3
Disrespect toward referee after warning	2–3

VIOLATION	SUGGESTED POINTS
Unsafe/reckless challenge	2–4
Prohibited sliding tackle	2–4
Tribal/ethnic insult or slur	3–5
Harassment or bullying	3–6
Threatening physical harm	5–8
Aggressive shove / attempt to start a fight	5–8
Physical fight / striking another person	8–12
Deliberate serious attempt to injure	8–12
Serious financial misconduct	8–12
Match manipulation / serious integrity violation	8–12

Accumulated Points

TOTAL POINTS	TYPICAL CONSEQUENCE
1–3	Warning / corrective action
4–6	Written warning and possible one-match suspension
7–9	Suspension of 1–3 matches and/or additional conditions
10–12	Extended suspension and disciplinary review
13+	Membership review; suspension or removal may be considered

> **Serious misconduct** may result in immediate suspension or removal, regardless of accumulated points.

ARTICLE

XV

Appeals & Fair Process

SECTION 1 Right to Appeal

KEY RULE

A member who receives a significant suspension, removal or other serious sanction may appeal within **seven (7) calendar days** of receiving the decision.

SECTION 2 Appeal Review

The appeal should be reviewed by people who were not directly responsible for the original decision, have no material conflict of interest, and can review the matter objectively.

SECTION 3 Grounds for Appeal

An appeal may be based on:

1. New relevant information.
2. A significant procedural error.
3. A conflict of interest.
4. A sanction that appears clearly out of proportion to the conduct.

SECTION 4 Finality

Once the club's appeal process is complete, the decision is final within the club, unless another lawful review process has been established.

SECTION 5 External Rules

Nothing in this Article prevents a player from using rights provided by law, league rules, facility rules or other governing authorities.

ARTICLE

XVI

Meetings, Voting & Amendments

SECTION 1 Meetings

The club should hold regular leadership meetings, membership meetings and an annual general meeting. The annual general meeting should review club direction, finances, leadership, membership, rules and future plans.

SECTION 2 Records

The Secretary should keep records of major club decisions, elections, constitutional amendments, important membership matters and significant financial decisions.

SECTION 3 Voting

Ordinary club decisions may be decided by a simple majority of eligible voting members present and voting, unless this Constitution requires a higher threshold.

SECTION 4 Major Constitutional Changes

KEY RULE

Amendments to fundamental provisions should require a **two-thirds (2/3) vote** of eligible voting members present and voting, provided reasonable notice of the proposed amendment has been given.

SECTION 5 Amendments

Any member in good standing may propose an amendment in writing. Proposed amendments should be reviewed and shared with members before a vote.

SECTION 6 Emergency Rules

The Executive Committee may adopt temporary operational rules when an immediate safety, facility, league or logistical issue requires action. Temporary rules should be shared with members and reviewed at the next appropriate meeting.

ARTICLE

XVII

Player Registration & Commitment Agreement

Naija FC Columbus — Player Commitment

I confirm that I am 18 years of age or older and that the information I provide during registration is accurate.

I have received, read and agree to follow the Naija FC Columbus Constitution, Rules & Regulations, including the club's standards on:

- Discipline.
- Player safety.
- Anti-tribalism.
- Verbal abuse.
- Physical altercations.
- Attendance.
- Financial obligations.
- Match-day conduct.
- Leadership accountability.

I understand that:

1. Sliding tackles are prohibited in club practice games and scrimmages, unless a specific competition rule is adopted.
2. Fighting, threats, harassment, tribal discrimination and dangerous play may result in suspension or removal.
3. The first 22 eligible players to physically check in for an internal full-sided practice game form the initial 22-player group, subject to safety and competition rules.
4. I may invite an adult non-Nigerian friend to take part in a practice game, subject to club approval, safety, space and applicable rules.
5. I must respect referees, opponents, teammates, coaches and club leaders.
6. Club membership does not give me the right to use club property or money for personal purposes.
7. I may be disciplined if I violate the Constitution.
8. The rules apply equally to all members, regardless of tribe, position, friendships, leadership status, football ability or financial contribution.

I agree to help make Naija FC Columbus a united, disciplined, safe, fair and respected football club.

ARTICLE

XVIII

Signature & Acknowledgment

By signing below, the member confirms that he has received, read and understood the Naija FC Columbus Constitution, Rules & Regulations and agrees to follow them.

MEMBER INFORMATION

Full Legal Name _____

Preferred Name _____ Date of Birth _____

Phone Number _____ Emergency Contact _____

Emergency Contact Phone _____

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

Member Signature _____ Date _____

Club Representative _____ Date _____



Final Commitment

I understand that the strength of Naija FC Columbus depends on every member doing his part. I will compete hard, respect others, protect the safety of my teammates and opponents, reject tribal division, respect the leadership structure, follow the rules, and help build a club culture of unity, discipline, fairness, accountability and brotherhood.

"One Team. Many Backgrounds. One Naija."

NAIJA FC COLUMBUS · CONSTITUTION & RULES · VERSION 1.0 · COLUMBUS, OHIO

Adopted by the Members on _____

President _____ Secretary _____

NAIJA FC COLUMBUS

EST. SEPTEMBER 8, 2026 · COLUMBUS, OHIO

Naija FC Columbus celebrates unity within Nigeria's rich diversity, bringing together people from many ethnic, cultural and religious backgrounds through a shared love of football. Built on integrity, respect and discipline, the club values every member and turns rivalry into brotherhood. Together, we are stronger.

One Team. Many Backgrounds. One Naija.